

Sūtra of the Terraced House

Kūṭāgārasūtra · Toh 332 · Derge Kangyur

ཁང་བ་བྱུང་སྟེང་པའི་མེད།

The Sūtra of the Terraced House, known in Sanskrit as the Kūṭāgārasūtra and in Tibetan as the Khang bu brtsegs pa'i mdo, is a short sūtra in which the venerable Ānanda asks the Buddha about the fruits of various meritorious acts — including making offerings of flowers, creating a maṇḍala, taking refuge, and observing the precepts of training. The Buddha's replies offer guidance on the karmic results of these foundational practices, making the text a practical teaching on the accumulation of virtue and the path of devotion. It is Toh 332 in the Kangyur, belonging to the general collection of sūtras, and is set in the familiar framing of the Jeta Grove at Śrāvastī, one of the most common settings for the Buddha's discourses.

In the language of India: Kūṭāgārasūtra. In the Tibetan language: the Sūtra of the Terraced House. Homage to the Omniscient One.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, in the residence of Prince Jeta.

Then the venerable Ānanda went to where the Blessed One was, and having arrived, he prostrated with his head at the feet of the Blessed One and sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words:

Blessed One, what does the root of virtue produced by making an offering of flowers become? What does making a maṇḍala become? What does the virtue of going for refuge and of the bases of training become? What does the virtue produced by the act of pressing palms together in homage to the Tathāgata become? Blessed One, what is it that causes the root of virtue not to be exhausted by wandering in saṃsāra and not to be used up by immersion in it, so that nirvāṇa is attained without its merit having been lost? And what does making an image of the Tathāgata become?

The Blessed One declared: Ānanda, the benefits of making an offering of flowers are fivefold. What are the five? Ānanda, they are as follows: one's own mind becomes clear; the minds of others become clear; the gods are gladdened; beautiful karma is made and accumulated; and when this body breaks up, one is born among the gods of the higher realms, the realms of

good destiny.

Ānanda, if someone makes a square maṇḍala for the sake of the Tathāgata, I declare that person will become the sovereign lord of Uttarakuru, the continent of Unpleasant Sound to the north, and that when this body breaks up, they will be born among the gods of the Thirty-Three.

Ānanda, if someone makes a round maṇḍala for the sake of the Tathāgata, I declare that person will become the sovereign lord of Aparagodānīya, the continent of Cattle-Enjoyment to the west, and that when this body breaks up, they will be born among the gods free from strife.

Ānanda, if someone makes a crescent-shaped maṇḍala for the buddha, the Blessed One, with a sincere mind, I declare that person will become the sovereign lord of Pūrvavideha, the continent of the Noble Body to the east, and that when this body breaks up, they will be born among the gods of Tuṣita.

Ānanda, if someone makes a maṇḍala in the shape of a chariot for the buddha, the Blessed One, with a sincere mind, I declare that person will become the sovereign lord of Jambudvīpa and that when this body breaks up, they will be born among the gods of Nirmāṇarati.

Ānanda, if someone goes for refuge to the Buddha, goes for refuge to the Dharma and the Saṅgha, and having undertaken the bases of training, maintains them fully and completely, I declare that the merit of that root of virtue is immeasurable and uncountable, and I declare that even all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas together could not encompass its limit, all the way up to the final attainment of nirvāṇa.

Then the Blessed One, understanding the mind of the venerable Ānanda, extended his tongue, which was like a petal of a red lotus — unstained, with soft leaves — like cinnabar red, like a leaf of the aśoka tree, and like a thin sheet of copper just covered by the width of water, stretching it from the center of his face all the way to the hairline at the crown of his head. He then spoke to Ānanda:

Ānanda, have you ever seen a tongue such as this on one who speaks falsehood, slander, harsh words, or idle talk? The Venerable replied: No, Lord, I have not. Ānanda, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, are speakers of truth. Ānanda, if someone presses their palms together and —

pays homage, saying "I pay homage to that Blessed One, that Tathāgata, that arhat, that perfectly and fully awakened buddha" — those sentient beings I shall gather in and lead beyond sorrow. I have little cause for worry on their behalf. Why is this? Ānanda, the dharmadhātu of the Tathāgata abides most firmly. And because it abides so firmly, even the mere pressing together of palms shall not go to waste — how much the less the performing of generosity and other such acts.

Ānanda, consider this. A certain person possesses even just enough water to have rinsed a small pot, or to have rinsed a bowl, or to have rinsed a ladle. If that person thinks, "May all the living beings dwelling here be made comfortable," and throws it into a drain hole — Ānanda, I declare that even this becomes a doorway to the arising of merit. How much the less need one speak of what happens for a human being.

Ānanda, these three are the intermediate aeons. What are the three? The intermediate aeon of weapons, the intermediate aeon of disease, and the intermediate aeon of famine. Ānanda, in this regard, whoever for even a single day abandons the taking of life and perfectly undertakes and maintains that precept shall not be born during the intermediate aeon of weapons. Whoever offers even a single āmalaka fruit to the Saṅgha shall not be born during the intermediate aeon of disease. And whoever offers to the Saṅgha even a ladleful of leftover food shall not be born during the intermediate aeon of famine.

Ānanda, the cultivation of these three roots of virtue shall not be exhausted within saṃsāra, shall not be fully depleted, and shall bring about the attainment of nirvāṇa that is inexhaustible. What are the three? Ānanda, cultivating a root of virtue toward the Buddha — this shall not be exhausted within saṃsāra, shall not be fully depleted, and brings about the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa. Cultivating a root of virtue toward the Dharma, and cultivating a root of virtue toward the Saṅgha — these shall not be exhausted within saṃsāra, shall not be fully depleted, and bring about the attainment of inexhaustible nirvāṇa.

Then, in order to reveal the qualities of the Tathāgata, the Blessed One spoke to Ānanda: Ānanda, have you seen the continent of Jambudvīpa? The Venerable replied: Yes, Lord, I have. Ānanda, the continent of Jambudvīpa measures seven thousand leagues in breadth, and seven thousand leagues across its waters. Its northern face is wide, and its southern end is shaped like

the body of a chariot. Now, if a faithful son of good family or daughter of good family were to fill that continent with the seven precious substances and offer them to the stream-enterers (those who have entered the stream), the once-returners, the non-returners, the arhats, the pratyekabuddhas, and the Saṅgha of monks of the four directions — and if another person were to engage in plastering the stūpa of a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has passed utterly into nirvāṇa, were to have even a myrobalan-sized portion applied; were to have erected even a flagpole of needle-height; were to have a canopy the size of a cypress leaf placed over it; were to have even a grain-sized image made; and were to have even a mustard-seed-sized portion of relics enshrined — Ānanda, I declare that this latter person's merit is immeasurably greater.

Ānanda, let alone the continent of Jambudvīpa — Ānanda, there is the continent to the east known as Pūrvavideha, which measures eight thousand leagues in breadth, eight thousand leagues across its waters, and has the appearance of a full moon all around. If a son of good family or —

a daughter of good family with faith were to fill that continent with all seven kinds of precious things and offer them to those who have entered the stream, those who return once, those who never return, the arhats, the pratyekabuddhas, and the monastic Saṅgha of the four directions — and yet another person were to cause even a grain-sized portion of clay from the stūpa of a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, to be made into something the size of an emblic myrobalan fruit; were to have even a needle-height flagpole erected over it; were to have a canopy the size of a cypress leaf placed over it; were to have even a grain-sized image made; and were to have even a mustard-seed-sized portion of relics enshrined — Ānanda, I declare that this latter person's merit is immeasurably greater.

Ānanda, let alone the continent of Jambudvīpa, and let alone the eastern continent of Pūrvavideha — there is the western continent known as Aparagodānīya, which measures nine thousand leagues in breadth, nine thousand leagues across its waters, and has the appearance of a crescent moon all around. If a son of good family or a daughter of good family with faith were to fill that continent with all seven kinds of precious things and offer them to those who have entered the stream, those who return once, those who never return, the arhats, the pratyekabuddhas, and the monastic Saṅgha of the four directions — and yet another person were to cause even a

grain-sized portion of clay from the stūpa of a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, to be made into something the size of an emblic myrobalan fruit; were to have even a needle-height flagpole erected; were to have a canopy the size of a cypress leaf placed over it; were to have even a grain-sized image made; and were to have even a mustard-seed-sized portion of relics enshrined — Ānanda, I declare that this latter person's merit is immeasurably greater.

Ānanda, let alone the continent of Jambudvīpa, let alone the eastern continent of Pūrvavideha, and let alone the western continent of Aparagodānīya — there is the northern continent known as Uttarakuru, which measures ten thousand leagues in breadth, ten thousand leagues across its waters, and is square in shape on every side. If a son of good family or a daughter of good family with faith were to fill that continent with all seven kinds of precious things and offer them to those who have entered the stream, those who return once, those who never return, the arhats, the pratyekabuddhas, and the monastic Saṅgha of the four directions — and yet another person were to cause even a grain-sized portion of clay from the stūpa of a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, to be made into something the size of an emblic myrobalan fruit; were to have even a needle-height flagpole erected; were to have a canopy the size of a cypress leaf placed over it; were to have even a grain-sized image made; and were to have even a mustard-seed-sized portion of relics enshrined — Ānanda, I declare that this latter person's merit is immeasurably greater.

Ānanda, let alone the continent of Jambudvīpa, let alone the eastern continent of Pūrvavideha, let alone the western continent of Aparagodānīya, and let alone the northern continent of Uttarakuru — there is the palace of Śakra, lord of the gods (Indra), known as Vaijayanta. If a son of good family or a daughter of good family with faith were to fill that palace with all seven kinds of precious things and offer them to those who have entered the stream, those who return once, those who never return, the arhats, the pratyekabuddhas, and the monastic Saṅgha of the four directions — and yet another person were to cause even a grain-sized portion of clay from the stūpa of a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, to be made into something the size of an emblic myrobalan fruit; were to have even a needle-height flagpole erected;

were to have a canopy no larger than a cypress leaf placed over it; were to have even a grain-sized image made from it; and were to have even a

mustard-seed-sized portion of relics deposited — Ānanda, I declare that this person accumulates merit far, far more abundantly than the other.

Ānanda, set aside even the continent of Jambudvīpa. Set aside even the eastern continent of Pūrvavideha. Set aside even the western continent of Aparagodānīya. Set aside even the northern continent of Uttarakuru. Set aside even the Victorious Palace of Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods. Ānanda, there is a world-system of a great trichiliocosm. If a son of good family or a daughter of good family were to fill that entire world-system with all seven kinds of precious things and offer them to those who have entered the stream, those who return once, those who never return, the arhats, the pratyekabuddhas, or the monastic Saṅgha of the four directions — and yet another person were to cause even a grain-sized portion of clay from the stūpa of a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha who has passed into complete nirvāṇa, to be made into something the size of an emblic myrobalan fruit; were to have even a needle-height flagpole erected; were to have a canopy no larger than a cypress leaf placed over it; were to have even a grain-sized image made from it; and were to have even a mustard-seed-sized portion of relics deposited — Ānanda, I declare that this person accumulates merit far, far more abundantly than the other.

And why is that? Ānanda, it is because a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha possesses immeasurable generosity, immeasurable moral discipline, immeasurable patience, immeasurable diligence, immeasurable meditative concentration, immeasurable wisdom, and from loving-kindness through to equanimity, all immeasurable. It is because a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha is endowed with immeasurable good qualities.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Ānanda and those monks rejoiced at what the Blessed One had taught and praised it with delight.

The Sūtra of the Multistoried Palace is complete.

Translated, revised, and established in final form by the great editor-translator Radanarākṣita.

Translator's Notes

- The sūtra's title Kūṭāgārasūtra refers to a multi-storied or gabled house, sometimes a peaked structure; "Terraced House" captures the general sense, though "Gabled Hall" or "Peaked

Chamber" are also defensible renderings.

The continent names — Uttarakuru, Aparagodānīya, Pūrvavideha, and Jambudvīpa — follow standard Buddhist cosmology for the four continents surrounding Mount Meru. The Tibetan epithets rendered here are: byang gi sgra mi snyan gyi gling (Uttarakuru, literally the northern continent of Unpleasant Sound), nub kyi ba lang spyod kyi gling (Aparagodānīya, the western continent of Cattle-Enjoyment), and shar gyi lus 'phags gling (Pūrvavideha, the eastern continent of the Noble Body).

The deity realms mentioned — the Thirty-Three (Skt. Trāyastriṃśa), the gods free from strife (Skt. Yāma), Tuṣita, and Nirmāṇarati — are the standard ascending sequence of desire-realm heavens.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, reflecting an incomplete source text.

- The Tibetan "ཡོད་པའི་ལོ་རྒྱུས་ལྟར་" in the context of the precept against taking life most naturally means "abides by it" or "maintains it," referring to upholding the vow throughout the day; this is rendered accordingly.

The phrase "ལྷ་མོ་ལྟ་བུ་ལྟར་" literally means "causing a flagpole of needle-size to be erected." The term "ལྷ་མོ་" (life-pole or flagpole) refers to the axial pole of a stūpa; rendered as "flagpole" for clarity.

"ལྷ་མོ་ལྟ་བུ་ལྟར་" — "ལྷ་མོ་" is a type of cypress or juniper; "leaf-sized canopy" is a standard stūpa miniaturization formula in such merit-comparison passages.

- The four continents follow the standard Buddhist cosmology: Jambudvīpa (south), Pūrvavideha (east), Aparagodānīya (west), and Uttarakuru (north). Their shapes are traditionally described as: Jambudvīpa like a chariot (trapezoidal), Pūrvavideha like a full moon (circular), Aparagodānīya like a crescent moon (semicircular), and Uttarakuru as square. The text's description of Aparagodānīya as "crescent moon" shaped (ལྷ་མོ་ལྟ་བུ་ལྟར་) fits this cosmological scheme precisely.

The Tibetan ལྷ་མོ་ (for Pūrvavideha) appears in two slightly variant spellings in the passage (ལྷ་མོ་ and ལྷ་མོ་), both rendered uniformly as Pūrvavideha.

- The colophon names the translator as Radanarākṣita, a well-attested Kashmiri paṇḍita active at the Tibetan imperial court in the early ninth century; the name is here rendered in its Sanskrit form as given in the colophon. The sūtra title rendered as "The Sūtra of the Multistoried Palace" reflects the Tibetan Khaṅbu brtsegs pa, corresponding to the Sanskrit Prāsāda likely in the title Prāsādasūtra or a related designation; no significant doctrinal uncertainty arises from this rendering.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.